



BROTHERS IN ARMS:
Pawar (left) and Thackeray

Strange Bilaterals

DELHI He claimed it was just a social visit but when NCP chief Sharad Pawar dropped in to meet Shiv Sena supremo Bal Thackeray at his Mumbai home for over an hour, it was hard to ignore the political nuances. Incidentally, the

visit occurred in the backdrop of Shiv Sena-turned-Congressman Narayan Rane's recent and rather blatant bid for chief ministership of Maharashtra.

Lashing out at Chief Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh's style of function-

ing, Rane had claimed that his rule benefited "only one person". Rane was summoned to 10 Janpath but the rap on his knuckles was a mild one. He was told that Margaret Alva, general secretary in-charge of the state, would handle the matter. Since Rane is reportedly being propped up by Alva in his dissidence against

Deshmukh, he did not seem too chastened.

In fact, Rane's criticism of Deshmukh followed his meeting with Alva in Delhi. "Rane's comments had nothing to do with me," protested Alva. However, Rane's supporters claim that he has been promised the chief ministership by the Centre. Both Pawar and Thackeray share a deep mistrust of Rane and don't want him as chief minister. Hence the visit was a clear message to 10 Janpath not to take the wishes of its allies for granted. More so as it came hours after the Congress's recent drubbing in Gujarat.

The seasoned politician and Maratha strongman knew exactly how to express his displeasure. He went to share a glass of the finest with a friend he hadn't met for years—the Congress beté noir, the Shiv Sena supremo himself. *by Priya Sahgal*

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

This could make CP(M) boss Prakash Karat go red in the face. A US-based Arms Control body has nominated him as Person of the Year for stalling the N-deal along with Henry Kissinger who campaigned passionately for the pact.

VOICES

"I kept my word, not Rajiv (Gandhi). He said he could not keep his promise to withdraw from Siachen and would do it only after the 1989 election."

Benazir Bhutto, former Pakistan prime minister

"We need one judge for 500 cases to clear the backlog. That means 77,664 judges. We need more courts and more budget for the judiciary."

K. G. Balakrishnan, chief justice of India

"I love India. I love Kolkata. I love Bengali culture and I will not leave India. I am not a criminal that I will not be allowed to return to Kolkata."

Taslima Nasreen, exiled Bangladeshi writer

"In a country like India, the development challenge is huge. No one can do it alone, not even the Government, despite best intentions."

Indra K. Nooyi, PepsiCo CEO

"Every captain has a shelf life. In India, a captain has to think about so many issues that sometimes he has no time to think about his game."

Sourav Ganguly, cricketer

